



Global Research and **Action** Agenda for Climate Change and Mental Health

Overview

Background to climate change and mental health

Overview of Connecting Climate Minds

Summary of regional and lived experience research and action agendas

Summary of Global Research and Action Agenda

Global priority actions

Case studies of existing research, interventions, and policies

Key takeaways

Resources

References



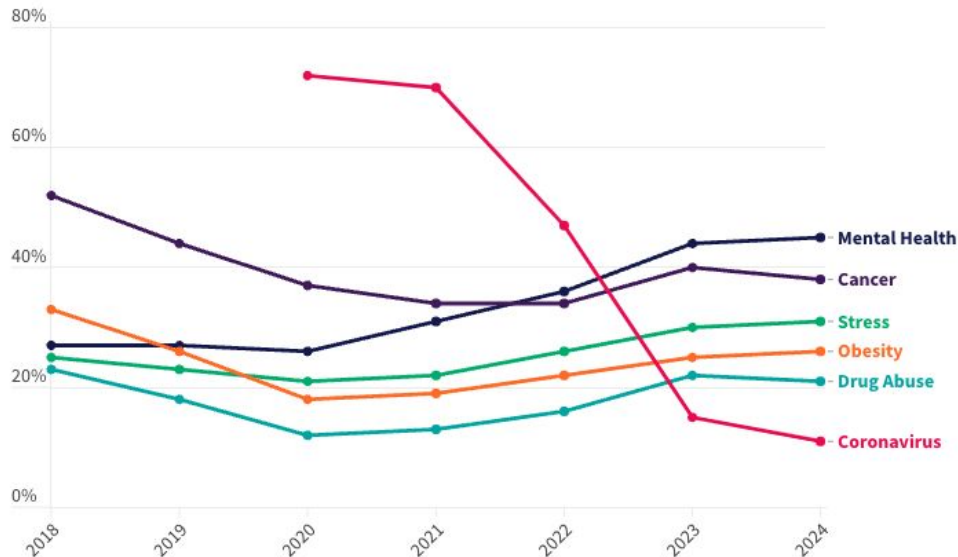
Climate change and mental health

Two interconnected crises

Mental Health

Mental health still the top health concern

Q: Thinking generally, which of the following, if any, do you see as the biggest health problems facing people in your country today?



Source: Ipsos Global Health Service Report 2024 • Base: 23,667 online adults under the age of 75 across 31 countries, interviewed 26 July – 9 August 2024.

1 in 8 people live with a mental disorder and suicide is a **major cause of death**. Yet:

- **<2%** national health care budgets are dedicated to mental health
- For half of global population:
1 psychiatrist for 200,000 people

(WHO World mental health report, 2022)

"Mental ill health, the leading health and social issue impacting young people, **has entered a dangerous phase**."

Global megatrends have increased mental ill health among young people."

(The Lancet Psychiatry Commission on Youth Mental Health, 2024)

Climate and Environmental Change

Living in a critical time: 6/9 planetary boundaries crossed. “Any further delay... will miss **a brief and rapidly closing window of opportunity to secure a liveable and sustainable future.**”

(Planetary Health Check, 2024; IPCC, 2022)

People want change

66–80% Americans support climate policies, but think only **37–43%** others do.

(Sparkman et al., 2022)

130,000 people in 125 countries: widespread support for climate action. **69%** willing to contribute 1% of personal income, **86%** endorse pro-climate social norms.

(Andre et al., 2024)

Do policies align with these desires and support people through change?

Resilience... not just the ability to maintain essential function, identity and structure, but also the **capacity for transformation.**

(IPCC, 2022)



Why climate change matters if you care about mental health



Climate change is a **risk multiplier**.

Its **consequences** will undermine progress on health and equity unless addressed.

Climate action can foster conditions for good mental health and well-being.

(WHO COP29 special report on climate change and health, 2024; Lawrance et al., 2022)

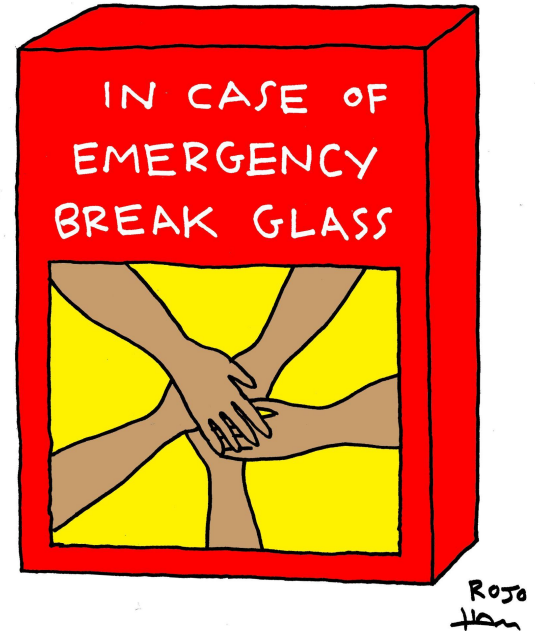
Why mental health and wellbeing matters if you care about climate change and energy transition

Health is a powerful lever of climate action: ultimate cost of the climate crisis and ultimate benefit of action. (Lawrance et al., 2021; Dasandi et al., 2022; WHO COP29 special report on climate change and health, 2024)

Wellbeing for all reinforces emissions reductions. (IPCC, 2022)

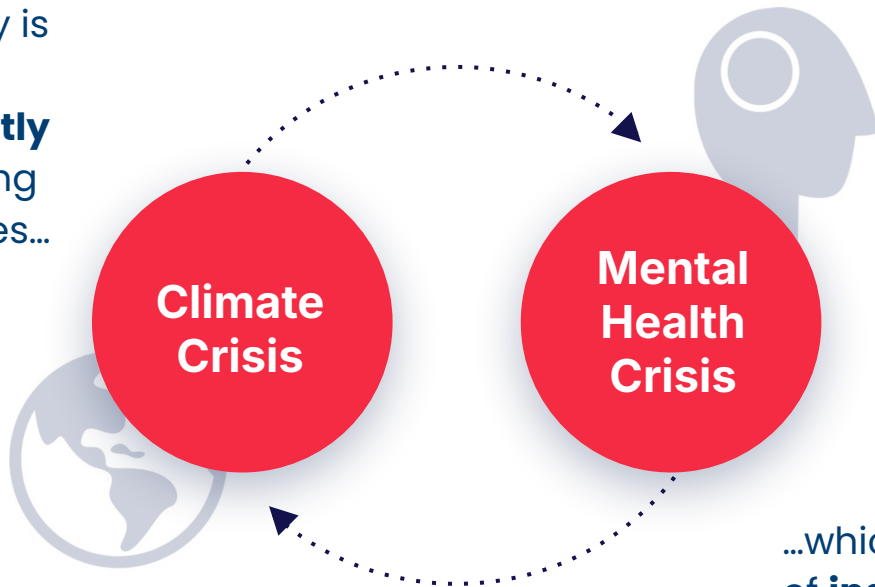
Psychological resilience is vital for societal transformation and climate resilience → coping with compounding stressors.

Psychological wellbeing of **people studying and working** in climate change needs support. (Pihkala, 2024; Lawrance et al., 2024)



Current **Vicious** Cycle

The climate emergency is also a **mental health emergency**, both **directly and indirectly** impacting mental health outcomes...



...which in turn limit the capacity of **individuals, communities and systems** to cope with and act on climate change.

Mental health impacts of climate change

Climate change **worsens mental health challenges and increases risk of new ones**

~10% higher hospital attendance for psychiatric disorders in heatwaves (Thompson & Lawrance et al., 2023)

Symptoms reported by people who experienced extreme weather event: anxiety (73%), depression (49%), PTSD (30%) (Climate Council of Australia, 2023)

Climate change **disrupts conditions needed for good mental health**

E.g., livelihoods, healthcare, education, cultural practices and social connection, forced migration and conflict, air pollution

Distress due to climate awareness, while adaptive and rational, can pose risks to mental health and wellbeing

Physical health impacts also have mental health consequences

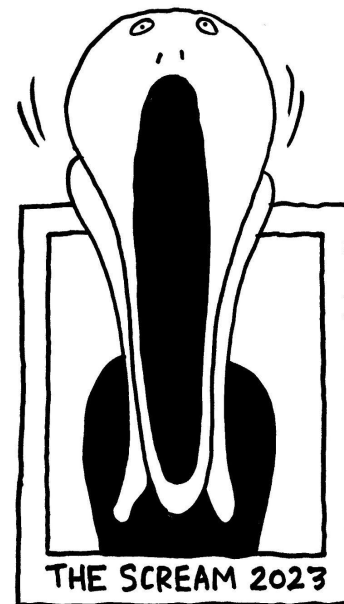
E.g., malnutrition, infectious disease spread

(IPCC, 2023; Lawrance et al., 2022; Ojala et al., 2021; Ogunbode et al., 2023; Lawrance & Newberry Le Vay et al., 2024)

Compounding risks to mental health

Mental health impacts of climate change **interact with other crises** e.g., conflict, migration, pandemics, structural inequalities.

Increasingly, people face **multiple compounding mental health risks** from repeated, chronic and multiple climate impacts.



ibm ROJO

(IPCC, 2023; Lawrance et al., 2022; Ojala et al., 2021; Ogunbode et al., 2023; Lawrance & Newberry Le Vay et al., 2024)

Climate change is a mental health risk multiplier

Vulnerabilities can be related to:

Health and disability

E.g., pre-existing mental health challenges

Race and ethnicity

E.g., Indigenous communities

Occupation

E.g., small farmers, fisher peoples, first responders

Age and life stage

E.g., children and older adults

Gender and sexuality

E.g., women and girls

Socioeconomic factors

E.g., conflict zones, experiencing homelessness, living in energy poverty

Geography

E.g., coastal areas prone to flooding

Institutional factors

E.g., living in prisons, long-term psychiatric institutions, care homes

(Lawrance & Newberry Le Vay et al., 2024)

What does this mean for societies?

537 billion USD per year by 2050: cost of the additional mental health burden due to climate hazards, air pollution and lack of green space (*Kumar et al., 2023*)

Growing mental health burden

Growing and changing mental health burden for health systems, which are often **already unable to respond** to mental health needs.

We need an environment that fosters mental health and wellbeing for all. **Climate change threatens this vision.**

(*The Lancet Psychiatry Commission on Youth Mental Health, 2024; WHO Mental Health Atlas 2020; Patel et al., 2018*)

Widening inequalities

Those **already most vulnerable or marginalised are most at risk.**

(*WHO Mental health and Climate Change Policy Brief, 2022; Lawrance et al., 2022*)

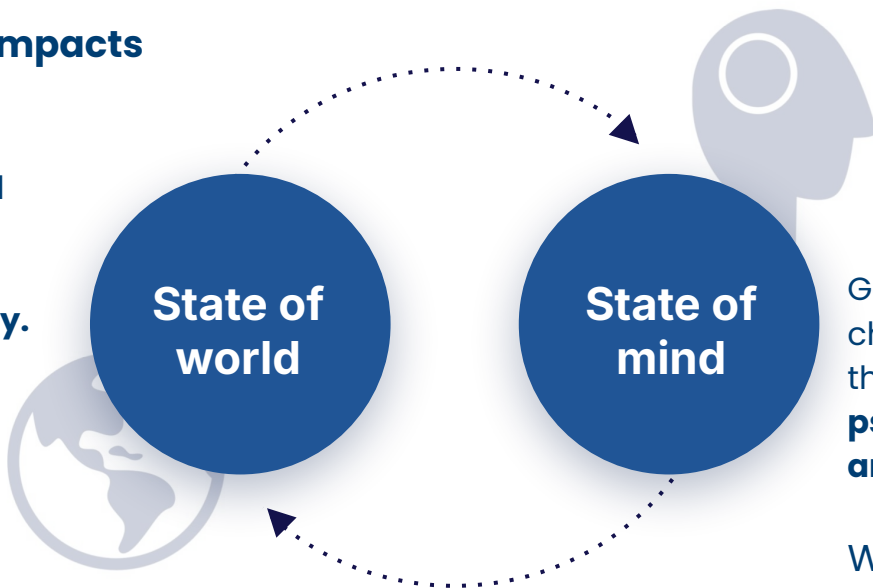
Potential for a Virtuous Cycle

Our state of mind also **impacts** the state of our world.

The climate and ecological crises are fundamentally attributable to **human behaviours and psychology**.



Source: *SustyVibes*



Generating individual and system change requires an awareness of the **interaction between our psychological response to crises and taking action**.

We need **positive social tipping points** before geophysical tipping points.
(*Otto et al., 2020; Armstrong McKay et al., 2022*)

Climate action and mental health action can align

Win-wins are possible: actions across sectors can mitigate mental health consequences of climate change and have potential to promote conditions for good mental health.

(IPCC, 2023; WHO Mental health and Climate Change Policy Brief, 2022; Lawrance et al., 2022; Jennings & Brandmayr, 2024)

Sustained climate action also likely **depends on psychological resilience and capacity for transformation.** *(IPCC, 2022)*



Where is climate and mental health research at?

Historically missed...

...but rapidly growing

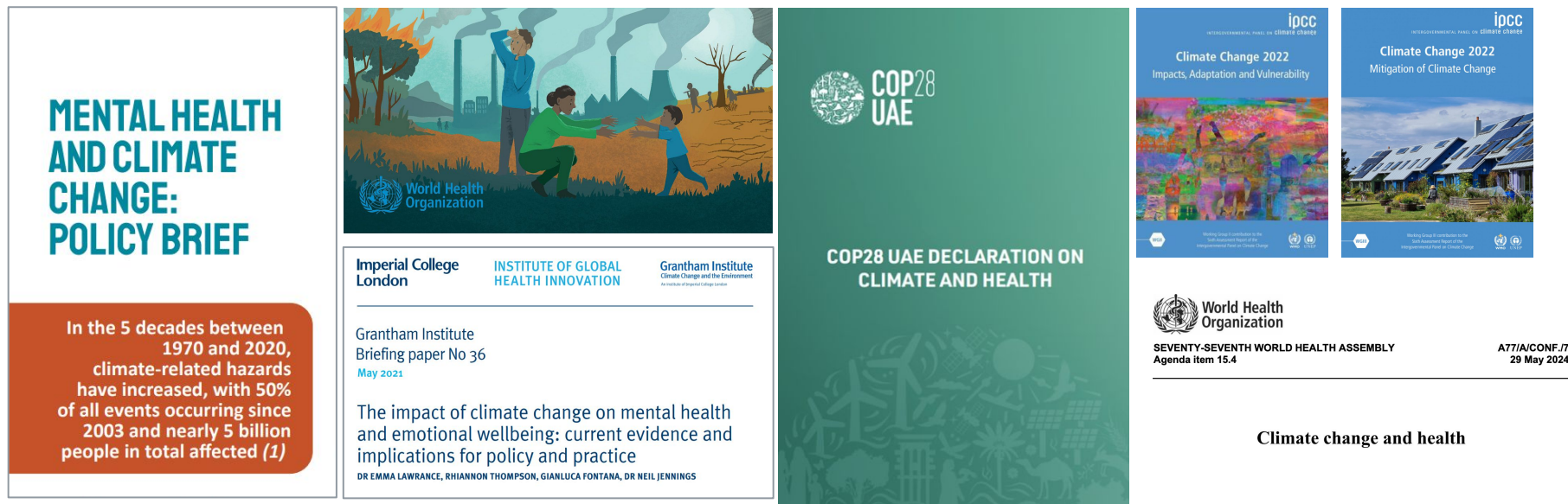
"A scarcity of robust data and relevant metrics has **undermined [the Lancet Countdown's] capacity to quantify and expose [mental health and wellbeing] impacts**, making it difficult for decision makers to adequately protect people's health from escalating climate-related harms...

...the need to support **a transdisciplinary field to measure and act on the climate – mental health nexus will only grow.**"

– Dr Marina Romanello, Director of the Lancet Countdown

Where is climate and mental health policy at?

Mental health impacts of climate change have received growing attention in recent years, reaching the highest levels of policy. However, this progress still greatly lags behind need.



The need for a research agenda

Mental health needs in the climate crisis are escalating globally. Decision makers need the right evidence to understand impacts and what actions work, where and for who.

There is **enough evidence to act** now, but key gaps remain.

Mental health **burden**
(including costs) is not
yet being fully measured,
particularly for those
worst affected

The **ways climate**
change impacts
mental health are
not fully understood

Mental health
benefits and risks of
climate action are
not being measured

Evidence is lacking
on **appropriate**
mental health
interventions

(Lawrance & Newberry Le Vay et al., 2024)

The need for an action agenda

How research is done is as important as **what** research is done.

Closer alignment of research and action is critical.

The climate and mental health field is rapidly growing, but is being held back.

Currently, the field is:

Disconnected

Disconnections across sectors, disciplines, methodologies, terminologies and regions.

Unequal

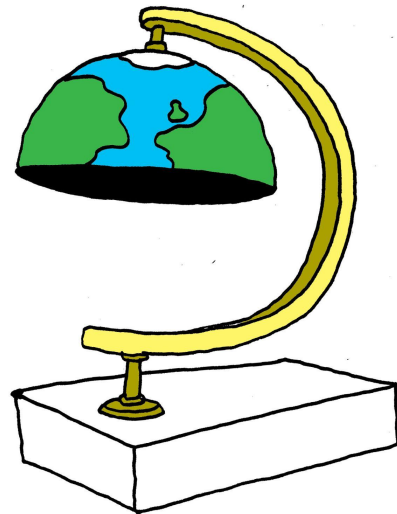
Focus is on certain geographies and topics.

Siloed

Siloed and de-prioritised policy making and funding slows action.

CLIMATE CHANGE
AND
MENTAL HEALTH
DATA GROUP

ham
Rosa

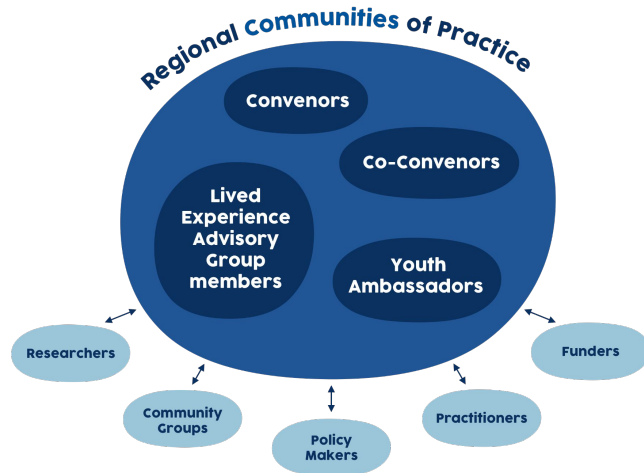


(Lawrance & Newberry Le Vay et al., 2024)

Connecting Climate Minds

Connecting Climate Minds Structure

Regional Community Teams led research and action agendas in all 7 [Sustainable Development Goal regions](#).



Lived Experience Working Group led research and action agendas globally with young people, Indigenous communities, small farmer and fisher peoples.



Climate Cares Centre and **Red Cross Red Crescent Climate Centre** provided global coordination and methodology.



Connecting Climate Minds Global Team



Outputs: a series of research and action agendas

7 regional agendas

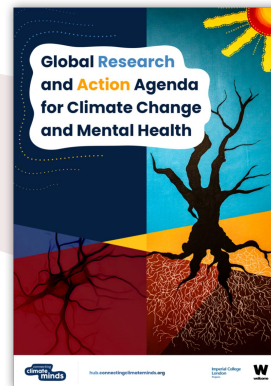
in every SDG region



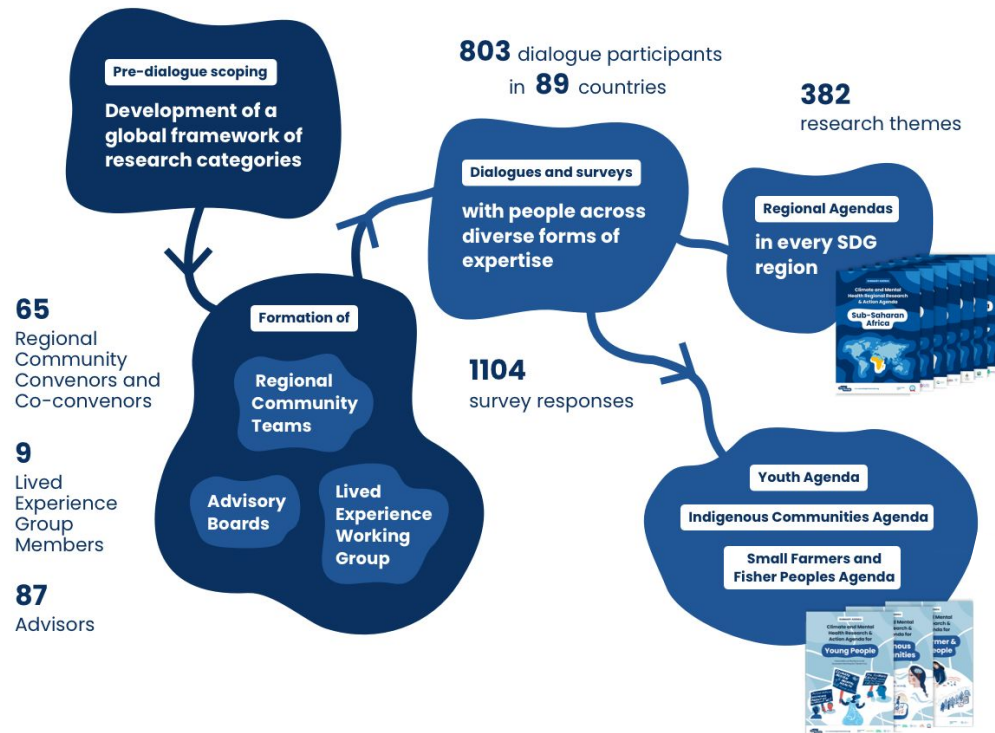
3 agendas for populations facing amplified climate mental health impacts:
young people, Indigenous communities, small farmers and fisher peoples



1 global agenda



Regional and Lived Experience Agenda Process



Summary of regional and lived experience agendas

Sub-Saharan Africa

Priority research to understand...

- How mental health **stigma, historical trauma and inequalities** affect access to care in the context of mental health and climate change in the region.
- **Existing coping mechanisms and resilience strategies** employed by communities in the region, e.g., the influence of Ubuntu culture.



Key actions

- Foster **transdisciplinary** research, including community-based research.
- **Integrate** mental health and climate change policies.

Northern Africa and Western Asia

Priority research to understand...

- Distinct **cultural understandings** of mental health, to guide identification of culturally-sensitive interventions for responding to climate-related mental health challenges.
- **Long-term consequences** of disrupted mental health determinants for marginalized populations in the region, and how to mitigate emerging climate-related challenges.

Key actions

- **Elevate research** on the climate change and mental health nexus and **integrate** this into relevant climate and/or health policies.
- **Secure commitment** from key relevant actors (e.g., funding, formalised partnerships).



Central and Southern Asia

Priority research to understand...

- How mental health **stigma** impacts understanding of climate-induced mental health challenges, and effective responses.
- **Readiness of health systems and services** to address mental health impacts of climate change.

Key actions

- Increase **understanding and awareness** among communities and service providers.
- Foster **transdisciplinary research**, which includes demographic disaggregated data to inform evidence-based interventions.



Eastern and South-Eastern Asia

Priority research

- Addressing climate-mental health **inequities** and caring for vulnerable groups.
- Incorporating **faith traditions & Indigenous knowledge** into climate-mental health interventions.
- Implementing **community-oriented and strength-based** approaches to climate-mental health action.

Key actions

- **Build capacity** of researchers and academic institutions in transdisciplinary climate-mental health research.
- Advocate for regional and national **policies that integrate** climate & mental health action.



Latin America and the Caribbean

Priority research

- Identifying **diagnostic tools** that should be used in the region and how these should be validated across large geographic regions.
- **Quantifying** the mental health burden associated with the climate crisis.

Key actions

- Identify the most effective interventions for fostering **collective community action**.
- **Securing funding** base to support transdisciplinary research across the region.



Oceania

Priority research

- Understanding and responding to climate change-related mental health and wellbeing in **diverse contexts** e.g., conceptual frameworks to integrate Indigenous ways of knowing, being and doing.
- Identifying and evaluating **locally-led, co-created climate actions** and their mental health and wellbeing outcomes.

Key actions

- Factor in **time** to build relationships and trust with communities, and ensure **reciprocity**
- **Holistic** framing of 'mental health and wellbeing', reflecting diverse forms of knowledge
- **Community-led** research and action, using participatory, strengths-based approaches
- Representation of **priority groups** in decision-making processes.



Europe and Northern America

Priority research

- Measuring mental health impact of climate-related **disruptions to determinants of mental health for Indigenous communities** e.g., disrupted culturally-based ceremonial practices, loss of blue and green spaces.
- Identifying how **climate policies** could mitigate or exacerbate mental health challenges among young people (e.g., integration of child rights principles).
- Evaluating efficacy of integrating mental health into **climate education**.

Key actions

- **Advocate** for dedicated funding and integrated climate and mental health initiatives
- **Build capacity** through training
- **Decolonize** climate and mental health work.



Youth

Priority research

- Understanding mental health and wellbeing **language and terminology** that resonates with climate-affected young populations
- Exploring short and long term nature of psychological **impacts** and climate related trauma in young people
- Identifying **climate actions** that integrate or align with mental health benefits

Key actions

- Invest in climate-mental health **services** for youth
- Climate action, and youth-inclusive **policymaking**



Indigenous Communities

Priority research

- **Tailoring mental health policy and interventions** to simultaneously promote ecological sustainability and mental well being in Indigenous populations
- Exploring mental health impacts of climate threats to **traditional ways of life and food sovereignty**

Priority actions

- Support **Indigenous community-led** research and action
- Strengthen culturally-responsive mental health **services**
- **Advocate** to protect traditional healing practices and Indigenous land sovereignty



Small Farmers and Fisher Peoples



Priority research

- Understanding how climate affects **anxiety and stress** for farmers, and point at which this **impacts functioning** in ways that constitute a mental health challenge

Priority actions

- Foster meaningful **co-creative partnerships** with small farmers and fisher peoples in research and intervention development



Summary of global research agenda

Introducing the Global Research and Action Agenda

A clear, inclusive, aligned vision is needed for climate and mental health research.

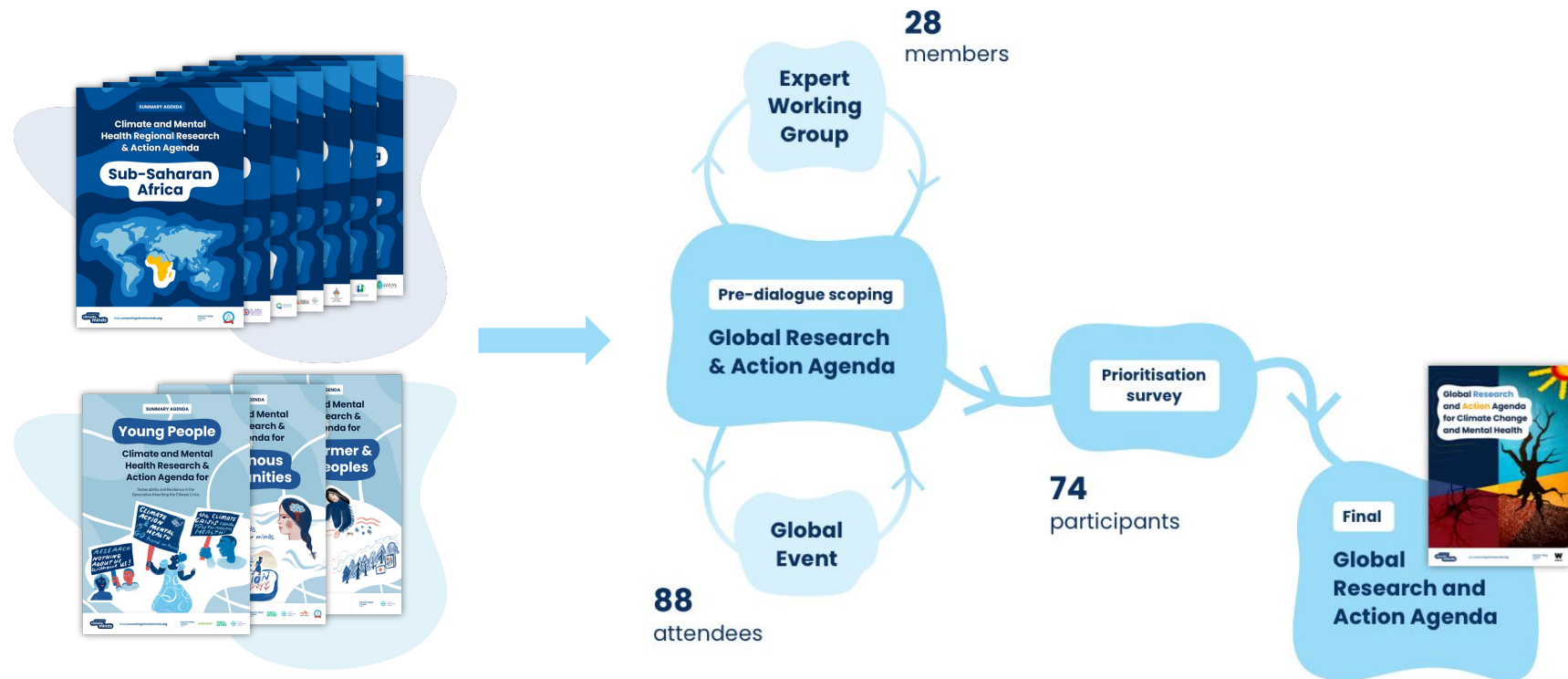
Informed by **960+ people in over 90 countries**, the global agenda aims to:

- **Target research** to help decision-makers respond to mental health needs resulting from climate change
- Provide an **action strategy** for implementing research and translating evidence
- **Build understanding** among diverse audiences of their roles in a transdisciplinary field.

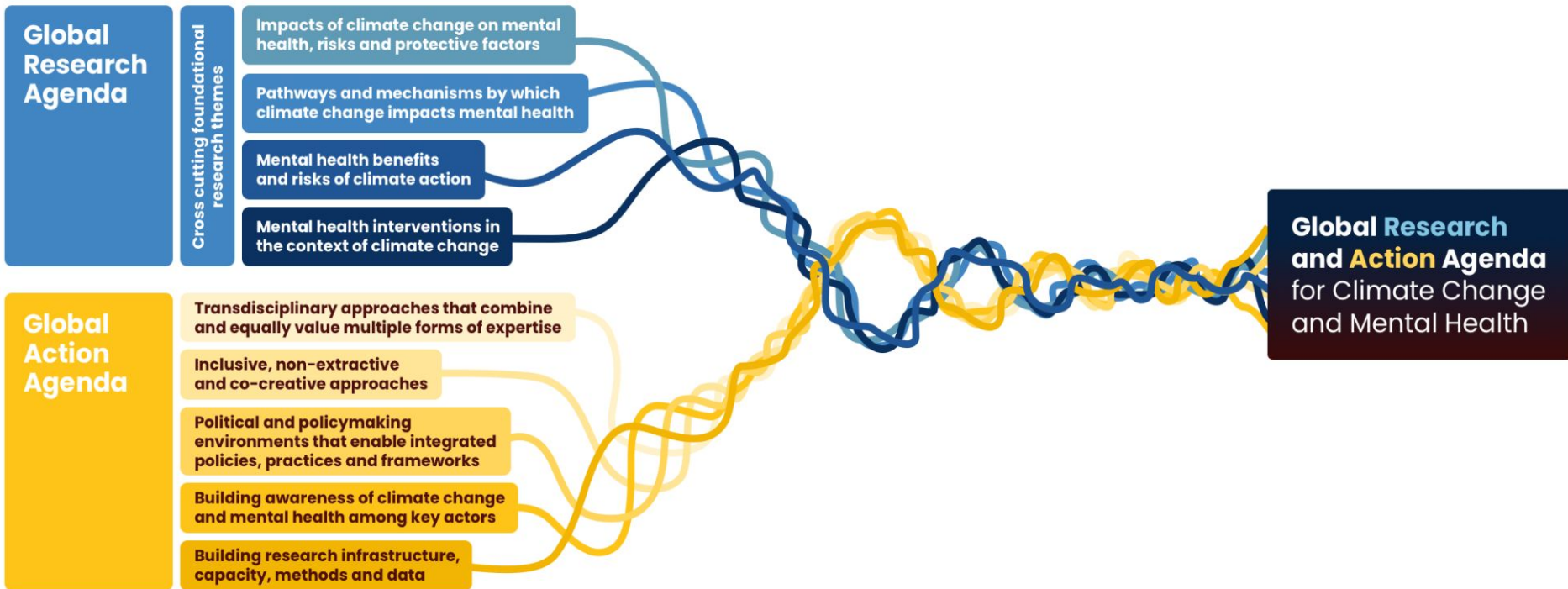


CONNECTING CLIMATE MINDS

Global Agenda Process



Global Agenda Structure



Global research agenda structure

The global research agenda contains:

- **Foundational research themes** needed to inform all climate and mental health research
- Four **high-level research categories**, each containing a set of priority research **topics** and specific research **questions**.

FOUNDATIONAL RESEARCH THEMES

Terminology, definitions and concepts

Methods, metrics and datasets

Existing knowledges, practices and interventions

HIGH-LEVEL RESEARCH CATEGORIES

Impacts of climate change on mental health, risks and protective factors

Pathways and mechanisms by which climate change impacts mental health

Mental health benefits and risks of climate action

Mental health interventions in the context of climate change

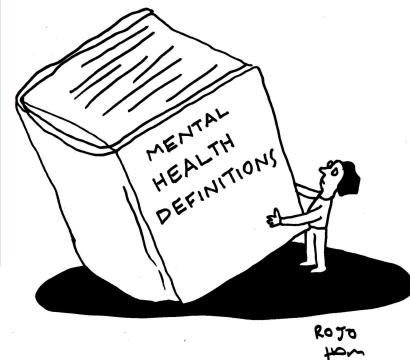
Foundational field building

Underpinning all climate and mental health research is the need to:

Develop shared
**terminology and
definitions** while
acknowledging
diverse
conceptualisations

Identify and
develop
appropriate
**methods, metrics
and datasets**

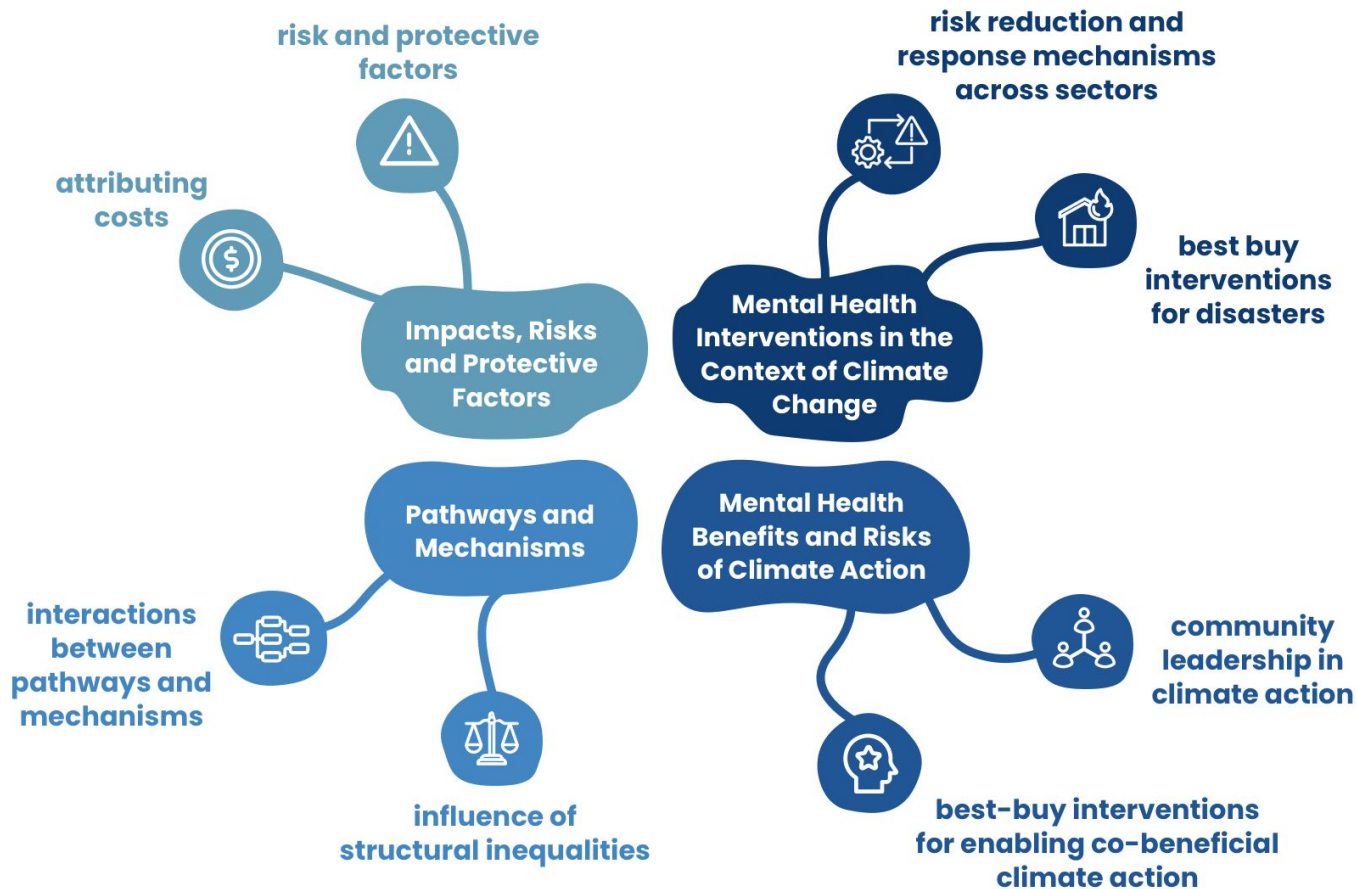
Learn from **existing
knowledge and
interventions** held in
diverse disciplines
and cultures



Priority research questions

Two "top questions" for each high-level category

Selected in a survey of 70 global experts



Global insights

Compounding mental health risks and multiple, interacting pathways and mechanisms

Relevant knowledge and solutions is held in diverse disciplines and cultures

Diverse expressions of mental health and of climate change → need for **foundational field building**

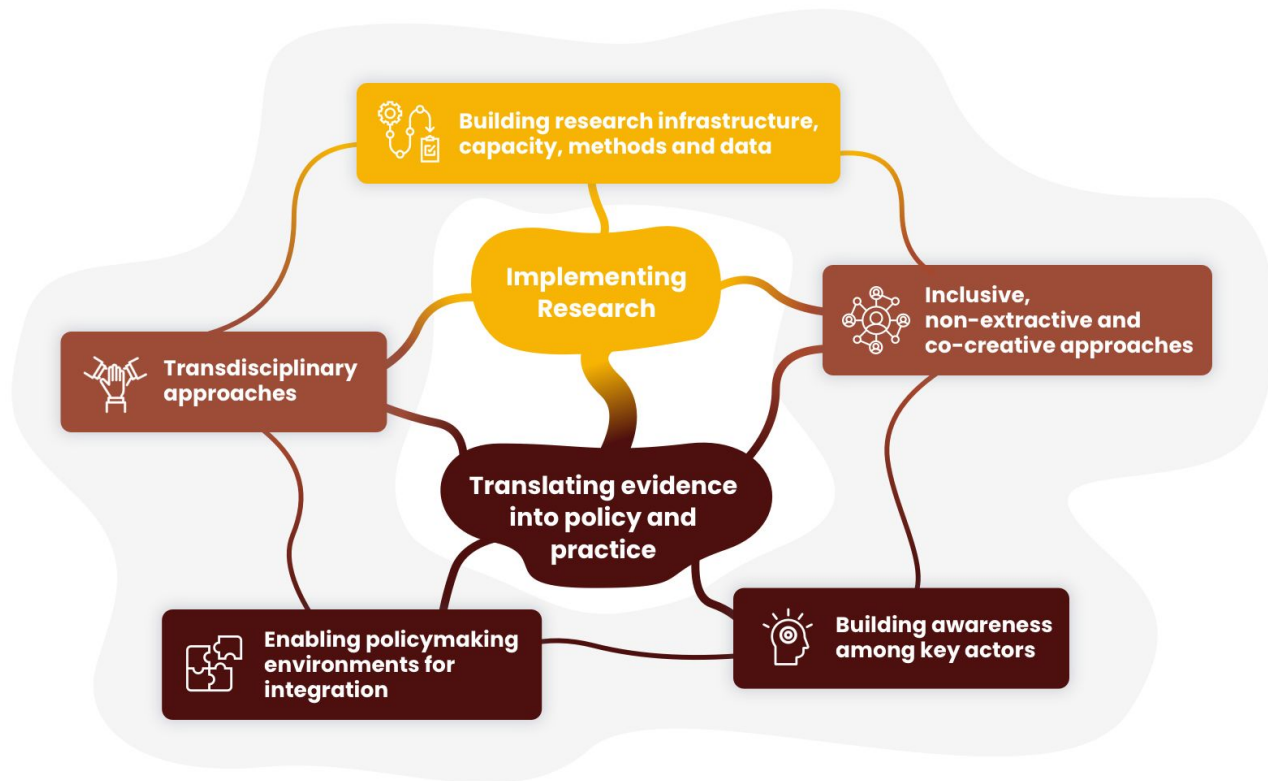


Summary of global action agenda

A vision for the climate and mental health field

How research is done matters as much as **what** research is done.

A shared vision exists, but this is currently held back by critical challenges.



Challenges holding back a shared vision

- **Lack of standardised and appropriate** methods, metrics and terminology
- **Funding structures and timelines** that prevent transdisciplinary, sustained relationship-building
- **Extractive research and exclusion** of lived experience, climate change-affected groups and Global South expertise
- **Siloed** decision making, governance mechanisms and budgets
- **Lack of awareness** and education

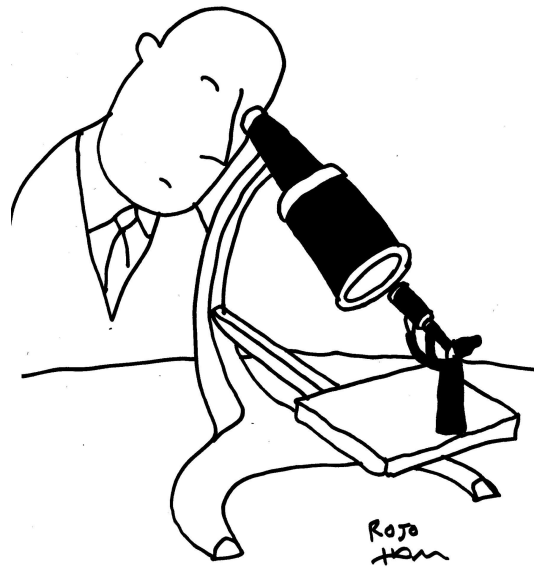
*"To decolonise and reindigenise research means to **value Indigenous ways of knowing, being and doing as equal** to Western ontologies and epistemologies."*

Oceania Research and Action
Agenda

Global priority actions

What can researchers do?

- **Prioritise inclusion** of communities and lived experience
- **Convene experts** to establish consistent frameworks, indicators and methods, appropriate for local contexts
- **Build networks and platforms** to share best practice and existing knowledge
- **Leverage existing areas** of research interest, data and capacity
- **Build relationships** with decision makers
- **Establish (with communities) data protocols** which encourage data sharing and increase trust in research.



What can research funders do?

- **Collaborate** with funders across disciplines
- **Fund creation and maintenance of platforms** for sharing data, methods, initiatives and organisations
- **Fund capacity and field building initiatives** e.g., transdisciplinary research networks, establishing frameworks and metrics, capacity building in countries with less research to date, establishing impact of such activities
- **Increase access to and inclusivity** of funding across geographies and diverse expertise
- **Mandate inclusion** of communities and community-based organisations in funding applications, with benefits back to communities.

What can policymakers and practitioners do?

- **Integrate mental health into climate and health policies, practices and frameworks (and vice versa).** E.g., National Adaptation Plans, Nationally Determined Contributions, disaster risk reduction and preparedness, climate-informed mental health surveillance, mental health system planning
- **Connect across decision-making silos** to explore how funding and decisions across sectors can account for costs, trade offs and benefits of climate action for mental health.



What can educators do?

Incorporate climate change and mental health into relevant educational curricula

(schools, universities, continuing professional development) to build capacity to recognise and respond to mental health impacts of climate change.

*"My country is experiencing excruciating impacts of climate change... the environment is not conducive to learning. And it exacerbates existing mental health issues. As a student, it **limits the possibilities, wellbeing, and educational capacity in the classroom.**"*

Youth Dialogue participant

What can civil society do?

- **Empower co-creation of research and practice** by connecting with other community-led organisations
- **Work with researchers to incorporate evidence into advocacy and relevant work.** E.g., incorporating mental health into climate and health, climate mitigation or adaptation activities (and vice versa)
- **Lead on effective monitoring and communication mechanisms** to gather information and feed data into research, policy and practice.



Case Studies

Existing research,
interventions, and policies

Examples case studies on the Global Online Hub



Inclusion of mental health in national health strategy and adaptation plans in Jordan

Jordan Health Aid Society International



Including mental health and climate change in Disease Prevention Law of Vietnam

Vietnam Environment Management Agency



Addressing mental health impacts of climate change through sustainable agriculture in Morocco

Moroccan Green Plan

Examples case studies on the Global Online Hub

Promoting community resilience in the USA by providing support tools (e.g., integrated data dashboards) to guide cross-sector initiatives, investments and decision-making

North Carolina Healthy & Resilient Communities Initiative



Co-creating interventions to build mental health and climate literacy grounded in traditional knowledge in Cameroon

Ibanikom, Kom Kingdom, Cameroon

Community-based psychological first aid training to build capacity for psychosocial support in Barbados

Barbados Ministry of Health and Wellness & PAHO

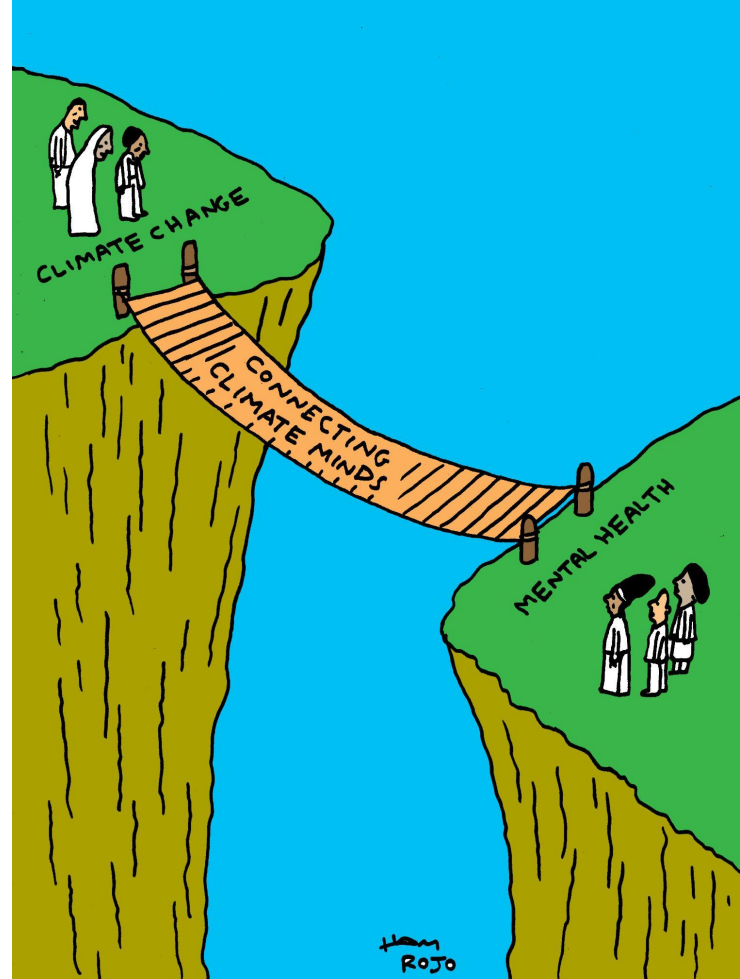
Key takeaways and further resources

Key takeaways

The global agenda sets out research priorities to help **generate evidence for decision-makers** to best respond to lived realities, informed by 960+ experts in 90+ countries.

How research is done is as important as what research is done. Research and action must draw on **diverse disciplines and knowledge systems, centring lived experiences.**

By acting **together**, we can better protect mental health from compounding burdens of a changing climate and achieve mental health benefits from climate actions.



"It's my desire that this work inspires meaningful, lasting change that honours the courage and meets the needs of vulnerable people."

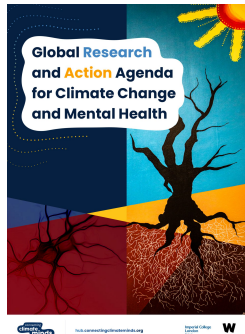
Hope Lekwa, SustyVibes, Nigeria & CCM Lived Experience Working Group



Resources

Research and Action

Agenda reports



Lived experience

stories from
around the world



Case studies showcasing
existing climate and
mental health research,
interventions and policies



Toolkits for researchers,
humanitarian decision
makers and lived
experience engagement



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